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First-year student Eric Zheng said he's giving up on going to classes at Northwestern University this quarter. Seasonal allergies have caused him to miss several lectures.

"It's so embarrassing," Zheng said. "My eyes just puff up, and I can't go to class."

The Centers for Disease Control and Prevention reports that 27.5% of adults in the U.S. suffered from a seasonal allergy in 2023. In recent years, allergy seasons have lasted much longer with more intense symptoms. Spring 2025 is no exception, and Northwestern students report that they have been experiencing a lengthy and intense allergy season this year.

Pollen:

Professor Gordon Smith, a professor of plant biology and conservation program assistant, said a mix of small particles such as dust, dirt and pollen contribute to seasonal allergies.

Courtney Teng, a nurse practitioner at NewYork-Presbyterian Weill Cornell Medical Center, said pollen is the main culprit.

"When a lot of plants are starting to blossom, they send out pollen in the air, and that's when people start breathing in all those allergens," Teng said.

Smith said a common misconception is that flowers pollinated by animals cause human allergies. Instead, it is wind-pollinated plants that are responsible.

"There's some flower species that get a bad rap for causing allergies," Smith said. "They happen to bloom at the same time as a different species that actually are producing a lot of pollen that gets in the air."

For example, the goldenrod flower gets the blame for the seasonal allergies caused by ragweed pollen.

"They just happen to both produce pollen at the same time," Smith said. "Only the ragweed is actually getting into the air and is being pollinated by wind in a way that would actually get into your lungs."

Symptoms:

Those who suffer from seasonal allergies can experience a range of symptoms. Teng said these include a runny nose, itchy and watery eyes and sneezing.

"Sometimes people get really drowsy just from experiencing all of that," Teng said.

Teng said symptoms can be the indicator between seasonal allergies and infections like colds.

"If your nasal drainage is starting to change color, it could be a sinus infection," Teng said.

"Those are major things that people can notice automatically if they have an infection versus allergies."

First-year student Noah Carver checks all the boxes for seasonal allergy symptoms. His symptoms include a runny nose and watery eyes.

"Stuffed-up nose too, not even just runny," Carver said. "I'll wake up, and I'll just feel malaise and tired."

Second-year Madeline Huang said her eyes are itching all the time in spring.

"Any time I'm outside, they start to itch," Huang said. "So I itch them and it looks like I got scratched because I itch them so much."

For Zheng, the itchy eyes have been his worst condition.

"My eyes start getting really itchy," Zheng said. "I was rubbing my eyes the other day and I felt like I almost tore my cornea."

Allergies this year:

According to the American Lung Association, the 2025 pollen season is approximately three weeks longer in the U.S. now than it was 50 years ago.

Smith said the increase in the volume of pollinating plants has contributed to the intense allergy season.

"The number distribution of plants that are responsible for these allergies are increasing either near humans or just generally increasing in these landscapes," Smith said.

Teng said that after the COVID-19 pandemic, many people may have developed a change in their sensitivity to allergens due to staying indoors and away from pollen.

First-year student Connie Gillum said she hasn't noticed a change in this particular allergy season.

"I think they might have been a little better," Gillum said. "Maybe that's just the trees talking, though."

Medicine:

Over-the-counter medicines such as Claritin and Allegra are safe for treating allergies, Teng said. She warns against the overuse of an Afrin decongestant nasal spray, which could result in a rebound effect.

"If you use it for more than three days, your symptoms actually come back," Teng said. "You might start feeling better, and if you use it for more than a specific amount of time, it actually comes back. Sometimes, it could be worse."

Gillum said she alternates between Allegra and Zyrtec each year.

"My dad has a conspiracy that if you take Zyrtec too much, it doesn't work," Gillum said.

Along with her eyedrops, Huang said she takes prescription allergy drops from an allergist.

"They would inject the allergy in my arm, so if it swelled up, then I would be really allergic to it," Huang said. "So then they would put that in the drop, and I would take it every day."

Zheng said he opposes any type of remedy and lets his allergies heal on their own—even if it means missing class.

"I just deal with them," Zheng said. "I don't bother with all the medicine stuff."

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- Courtney Teng, nurse practitioner, New York, New York, 646-945-5285, interview conducted over call on June 2, 2025

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